

Hi Is Not a Subject Line

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Essay

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Because “hi” is not a subject line, “quick question” is a threat, and empty email bodies should be illegal.

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The other morning, I opened my email with the same optimism a man brings to checking the bottom of a trash can for a missing car key. Not because I thought anything wonderful was waiting for me. I am not a child. I do not believe in magic. I just needed to find one actual message from one actual human being about one actual thing.

Instead, there it was.

Subject line: “quick question”

Body: nothing useful for at least four sentences.

This is how civilization ends. Not with fire, not with robots, not with some dramatic movie scene where the power grid collapses and everyone starts wearing leather vests. It ends with a grown adult sending an email titled “hi” and making me open it like I am defusing a bomb in a cubicle.

To be fair, I know email was never exactly a sacred art form. Nobody is asking for parchment, a wax seal, and a monk hunched over by candlelight carefully writing, “Regarding the Johnson invoice, third revision.” I understand we are all busy. We are all tired. Most of us are just trying to get through the day without accidentally replying all to something that should have died quietly in committee.

But what the hell happened to subject lines?

At some point, the subject line stopped being the helpful label on the outside of the box and became either a fortune cookie, a hostage note, or the entire email crammed into one long sentence like somebody was charged by the paragraph. We have apparently decided there are only two options now. Either the subject line says “question” and gives me no clue whether the question is about dinner, taxes, my child, a work emergency, or whether I still own a ladder, or the subject line says, “Can you send me the revised version of the document with the updated pricing before the meeting tomorrow morning if you still have access to the shared folder thanks,” and then the body is completely empty.

That one is my favorite. The empty body email.

Nothing says “professional communication” like making me read a sentence in a preview pane that cuts off right before the only part I need. I have to widen the column, squint at the screen, hover over the message, open it anyway, and discover that there is no body because apparently the subject line was the body, the greeting, the request, the closing, and the emotional journey.

We have invented email as a bumper sticker.

And the worst part is that this is not just spammers. Spammers, at least, have an excuse. They are criminals, robots, or criminal robots. I expect nothing from them. If a spammer sends me a subject line that says, “Urgent response needed regarding your account,” I know the game. I can delete it with the calm confidence of a man who did not order medical-grade vitamins from an offshore warehouse at 2:13 a.m.

But family does this.

Coworkers do this.

Normal, functioning people with mortgages, children, pets, opinions about air fryers, and the legal right to operate motor vehicles do this.

A family member will send an email with the subject line “Look” and an attachment. No explanation. No context. Just “Look.” Look at what? A recipe? A funeral notice? A coupon? A picture of a raccoon sitting on a patio chair like he owns the place? I don’t know. Now I have to open it, because that is how family works. We are bound together by blood, love, obligation, and a shared inability to label things properly.

At work, it gets even better. Someone sends an email with the subject line “Thoughts?” That’s it. No topic. No object. No hint. Just “Thoughts?” Like I am sitting in a chair wearing a cardigan, waiting to provide general philosophical commentary on the human condition.

Thoughts on what, Gary? The budget? The new client? The meeting invite you sent with no agenda? The fact that the office coffee now tastes like someone filtered regret through mulch?

I’m with you, we do not need every subject line to be a legal filing. But we do need it to perform the one job it was born to do. A subject line should tell me the subject. That seems fair. It is right there in the name. We did not call it the “vague emotional opening line.” We did not call it the “tiny mystery window.” We called it the subject line because, in a healthier time, it was supposed to identify the subject.

I miss that.

I miss when labels meant something. I grew up in the 80s and 90s, when if someone wrote “Vacation 1992” on a VHS tape, there was at least a fighting chance that tape contained Vacation 1992. It might also contain the last twelve minutes of a Brewers game, part of a Christmas special, and a commercial for a discontinued cereal that looked like packing peanuts dipped in sugar, but still, somebody tried. There was an effort. There was a basic respect for the next poor soul who would have to figure out what was on the tape.

Now we have unlimited digital storage, searchable inboxes, AI assistants, smart folders, filters, tags, stars, pins, flags, rules, reminders, nudges, prompts, and seventeen different ways for a computer to tell me I have not responded to something I never understood in the first place.

And still, the subject line is “hi.”

How did we get worse at this?

Part of it, I think, is that every form of communication has leaked into every other form until nothing has borders anymore. Texting infected email. Email infected chat. Chat infected work. Work infected home. Home infected everything. Now someone will send a professional email subject line that reads like a text from a teenager trying to make plans from the passenger seat of a moving car.

“hey u free tmrw?? 🧐”

No. Not in email. Absolutely not.

I am not against emojis. I am not made of stone. There are appropriate places for them. A thumbs up in a text is fine. A smiley face from your kid is nice. A little laughing face in a family thread can save everyone from reading tone into something that was probably just Uncle Dave being Uncle Dave again.

But in an email subject line? From a vendor? About a contract?

No.

And the acronyms. Lord help us, the acronyms. Every generation has its shorthand, for sure, but email is not the place to test whether the recipient has been keeping up with whatever linguistic confetti is currently blowing through the internet. If I have to stop and decode your subject line like it is a captured wartime transmission, we have already failed.

“Need this ASAP” is annoying but clear.

“Low-key need ur POV fr” makes me want to walk into the woods and start over with a notebook and a pencil.

I know that makes me sound old. Oh well. At some point, being old just means you remember when tools had purposes and people pretended to care about them. A hammer was for hammering. A phone call was for something that needed back-and-forth conversation. A text was for quick coordination. Email was for things that needed a little structure, a little record, a little context.

Now everything is everything.

If it is truly a quick question, why are you emailing me? Text me. Call me. Walk over, if we are in the same building and you are not carrying a contagious disease or a full lunch plate. Do not send me an email that says “quick question” and then hide the question six lines down after “Hope you’re doing well” and “Just circling back” and “No rush, but also this is apparently urgent because you marked it high importance.”

Quick question is not a subject line. It is a warning.

And while we are here, can we talk about the fake politeness that clogs up these messages? I do not need a full preamble before you ask me where the file is. I do not need a weather report, a wellness check, and three lines of apology before the point arrives limping into the room. Just say, “Need Q2 budget file by 3 p.m.” That is a subject line. It tells me what you need and when. I can respect that. I may still complain, but I will respect it.

The subject line should be the grocery store aisle sign of the email. Cereal. Bread. Paper towels. It does not need to say, “A nourishing and emotionally satisfying grain-based breakfast experience awaits.” It just needs to tell me where the cereal is.

Instead, modern subject lines are either blank emotional gestures or full novels written in a space designed for a label.

There should be rules.

I need an automatic filter for stupid subject lines. Not a spam filter. A shame filter. Something built into every email client that quietly reviews your subject line before sending and says, “Are you sure you want to burden another human being with this?”

If the subject line is “hi,” the system should pause and ask, “Is this 1998 AOL Instant Messenger, or are you attempting to communicate about a specific matter?”

If the subject line is “quick question,” the system should ask, “Would this be better as a text, a call, or a quiet moment of personal reflection?”

If the entire message is in the subject line and the body is empty, the email should bounce back with a mandatory notice: “Your email has been returned because you attempted to use the subject line as a shipping container. Please enroll in a basic email etiquette class soon. Bring a notebook. You may need help.”

In true Rob fashion, I would probably create this rule, test it, accidentally delete something important from the dentist, and then spend two hours proving my own point while muttering at a laptop.

Still worth it.

Because beneath all the joking, there is something real here. Bad subject lines waste time, yes, but they also show a small failure of consideration. Not a crime. Not a scandal. Not something we need to form a national commission over, although I would watch those hearings. But it is one more tiny place where we make someone else do the work we did not feel like doing.

That is what bothers me.

A good subject line is a small act of mercy. It says, “I know your attention is limited. I know your inbox is a mess. I know you have a life outside this message. Here is what this is about.”

That is not fancy. That is basic decency.

And maybe that sounds like too much moral weight to put on an email subject line. Maybe it is. Maybe I am just a tired man staring at an inbox wondering why “Update” could mean anything from a changed meeting time to the collapse of a vendor relationship. But at the end of the day, communication is one of the main ways we show each other whether we are paying attention. Not perfectly. Nobody gets it right all the time. But enough to say, “I thought about the person receiving this before I sent it.”

That matters.

We live in a go-go-go world where everyone is overwhelmed and nobody wants one more rule. I get it. I do not want more rules either. Half the time I want fewer rules, fewer logins, fewer codes texted to my phone, fewer apps asking me to rate my experience buying socks.

But this is not really about rules. It is about remembering that on the other side of every message is a person who now has to stop what they are doing and figure out what you meant.

So here is my modest proposal, which I assume will be ignored by everyone immediately.

Write the subject line last.

After you have written the email, ask yourself one question: “What is this actually about?” Then put that answer in the subject line. Not your mood. Not your greeting. Not your entire request written like a ransom note in a single strip of text. Just the point.

“Dinner Sunday?”

“Invoice question for March order.”

“Need approval on school form.”

“Updated schedule for next week.”

“Can you call me about Mom?”

See? Nobody died. No one had to learn a new platform. No dashboard was created. No consultant was hired. We just used words for their intended purpose, which apparently now qualifies as radical discipline.

The funny thing is, most of us already know this. We know when a message is clear. We feel the relief of it. We open an email and immediately understand why it exists. It is beautiful in the way ordinary competence is beautiful. Like a gas pump that prints a receipt. Like a hotel shower with controls that do not require an engineering degree. Like a drawer where the scissors are actually in the drawer.

Not heroic. Just helpful.

And that is all I want from email subject lines. I do not need poetry. I do not need personality. I do not need a tiny suspense thriller called “Question.” I need a label. A simple, honest label that tells me whether I should open this now, later, or after I have had enough coffee to forgive the person who sent it.

That is not too much to ask.

Put the point where the point belongs.